

What pool closures in Canada mean for health

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■ Cite as: *CMAJ* 2026 June 29;198:E980-1. doi: 10.1503/cmaj.260959

Community pools are disappearing from the Canadian landscape, often among the first casualties of tightening public budgets. Although some may view public pools as “nice to have,” these facilities must be seen as essential tools in the public health arsenal. Aquatic activities offer unique and versatile health and social benefits for healthy individuals and those with pre-existing medical conditions, and swimming is a critical life skill. A unique opportunity to repair and build neglected pool infrastructure exists in the Community Stream of the federal government’s Build Communities Strong Fund initiative, announced in March 2026.¹ We argue aquatic facilities should be prioritized in the disbursement of the \$30 billion in available funding.

Development of pool infrastructure in Canada has not kept pace with population growth. Frequent news reports highlight waiting lists for swim lessons,² temporary and permanent pool closures,^{3–5} and community-led attempts to save pools, including court challenges.⁶ According to Statistics Canada data, many public pools are at or nearing the end of their lifespan, with only about half rated in good or very good physical condition in 2022.⁷ Downsizing replacement pools further limits access, as 50-m pools can offer up to 3 times as much programming as 25-m pools.⁸

Swimming is widely regarded as one of the most effective full-body workouts, simultaneously loading almost all major muscle groups against the resistance of water while supporting cardiorespiratory fitness. A 2024 meta-analysis of longitudinal studies of sports interventions found that swimmers had a 24% lower rate of all-cause mortality than nonparticipants.⁹ In a 2019 British study, swimming was associated with a 6.4% improvement in general health, including a 3.1% improvement in mental health, compared with the average population.¹⁰ Buoyancy makes swimming a low-impact activity accessible to people of all ages and fitness levels, particularly for those with limited mobility because of disability, injury, or pregnancy. A 2022 meta-analysis showed improvements in balance, strength, pain, cardiorespiratory fitness, and quality of life with 8 to 16 weeks of pool-based therapy in patients with multiple chronic conditions, including fibromyalgia, hypertension, coronary artery disease, multiple sclerosis, and Parkinson disease.¹¹ Pools are also a means to mitigate heat stress. Research in New York found that, as the heat index increases, heat-related emergency calls increase directly with walking time to a pool, particularly in low-income neighbour-

hoods, possibly owing to the lower availability of cooling options in these areas.¹² Aquatic facilities can save health systems money; swimming participation at public facilities in England was estimated in 2022 to save England’s National Health Service more than £191 million a year, primarily related to reduced risk of dementia, diabetes, coronary artery disease and stroke, hip fracture, psychotherapy usage, and general practitioner visits.¹⁰

Importantly, learning to swim reduces a person’s risk of drowning. In 2019, Canada ranked 19th worldwide in the percentage of people aged 15 years and older being able to swim without assistance, behind many countries with far less natural water.¹³ Past participation in formal swimming lessons was associated with reduced risk of death by drowning in a 2009 case-control study of 88 cases of unintentional drowning in children and adolescents.¹⁴ Yet, a 2010 survey found that only 41% of people new to Canada in the previous 5 years had ever taken swimming lessons.¹⁵ Avoiding swimming entirely is not a reliable strategy to prevent drowning; of the more than 400 people who fatally drown in Canada each year, roughly 1 in 5 did not intend to end up in the water.¹⁶

Although people of all ages and abilities experience the effects of Canada’s deteriorating and disappearing public pools, limited access disproportionately affects families with children, immigrants, Indigenous Peoples, people with chronic conditions, and people with low incomes. For young families, open pool time and parent-and-baby programs are an important space for recreation and social connection. However, parents identify limited access to pools and high annual lesson costs as barriers to their children participating in swimming.¹⁷ In 2020, 26% of all pools in Canada were not accessible to people with disabilities, with a higher proportion in rural areas.¹⁸ Pool infrastructure is particularly lacking in Indigenous communities.¹⁹

Canada is at a critical point in determining the fate of its swimming infrastructure. Although the Build Communities Strong Fund could be a powerful mechanism to address funding needs, solutions need to be more extensive and ongoing. Children, youth, and people new to Canada should have universal access to basic water safety and swimming skills to prevent drowning;²⁰ communities can address equity concerns by offering free swimming lessons to children.²¹ Statistics Canada should provide consistent, comparable data to enable clear tracking of pool numbers and public access to them, including

distribution per capita and across socioeconomic contexts. Governments at all levels must ensure that every community has access to year-round pool facilities. Priority should be given to retrofitting pools for accessibility, replacing aging 50-m pools with same-size amenities, and building new pools in Indigenous communities, areas of lower socioeconomic status, and areas with higher numbers of people new to Canada. Multiple reports identify the community, business, and cultural benefits of pools.^{8,16,19} The health and safety benefits of swimming must likewise be top of mind as governments choose whether or not to throw community pools a life preserver.

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Competing interests: www.cmaj.ca/staff

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